PRACTITIONER REFERENCE

Pressure & Endangerment Guide

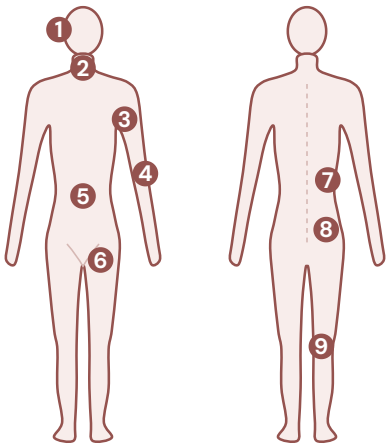
Work within comfort and protect vulnerable areas.

Pressure scale

LEVEL	FEEL	TYPICAL USE	CLIENT CUE WORDS
1 · Very light	Skin surface; slow glide	Lymphatic work, fragile skin, bony areas	"Barely there"
2 · Light	Soothing; muscles stay soft	Relaxation, prenatal, older or frail clients	"Gentle," "relaxing"
3 · Moderate	Firm but comfortable	Most Swedish sessions; warming tissue	"Just right," "firm"
4 · Firm	Deep; a "good hurt"	Deep tissue, sports, specific tight areas	"Good pressure"
5 · Very firm	Near the client's limit	Brief, targeted work only; check in often	"That's my max"

Check in often. A "good hurt" is fine; sharp, burning or radiating pain means stop.

Endangerment sites



1. **Eyes & ears.** No pressure on the eyeball or into the ear canal.
2. **Anterior neck.** Carotid, jugular, trachea. No deep or sustained pressure.
3. **Axilla.** Brachial plexus, axillary vessels, nodes. Light only.
4. **Inner elbow.** Cubital fossa: median nerve, brachial artery. Light only.
5. **Abdomen.** Aorta. No deep pressure; move away if you feel a pulse.
6. **Femoral triangle.** Femoral artery, vein, nerve. Avoid deep pressure.
7. **Kidney area.** Below the 12th rib. No tapotement or deep pressure.
8. **Sciatic notch.** Sciatic nerve. Ease off if pain or tingling radiates.
9. **Posterior knee.** Popliteal vessels and nerve. Light only.

> Pulse, numbness, tingling or sharp pain? Ease off and move away.

Modalities compared

MODALITY	PRESSURE	LENGTH	KEY CAUTIONS
Swedish	2–3	60 / 90 min	Tenderness for 24–48 h can happen.
Deep tissue	3–5	60 / 90 min	Blood thinners, osteoporosis, acute injury. Soreness 24–72 h.
Sports	2–5	30–90 min	Pre-event brief and brisk; post-event light. Skip acute injuries.
Prenatal	1–3	60 min	Side-lying after ~20 wk; light legs; no deep abdominal work.
Hot stone	2–3	75–90 min	~120–130°F [per maker]. Avoid neuropathy, heat sensitivity.
Cupping	2–4	30–60 min	No blood thinners, fragile skin or large vessels. Marks [3–10] days.
Lymphatic	1	45–60 min	Screen fever, DVT, CHF, kidney failure. Surgeon OK post-op.

OILS, LOTIONS & MEDICATIONS

- **Ask about nut allergies** (almond oil and others).
- Keep a nut-free, fragrance-free option on hand.
- Essential oils diluted [1–2%]; minimal in pregnancy.
- Pain meds, muscle relaxants dull feedback: go lighter.
- Blood thinners bruise easily; steroids thin the skin.
- Pump-dispense oils and lotions; never double-dip.

Scope. Massage therapists don't diagnose. Refer when in doubt, and check your state board rules.